frontiers in Education

TYPE Perspective
PUBLISHED 23 July 2026
DOI 10.3389/feduc.2026.1899614

Check for updates

OPEN ACCESS

EDITED BY
Susan Louise Lindsay,
University of Glasgow, United Kingdom

REVIEWED BY
Andrew Fletcher,
Durham University, United Kingdom

*CORRESPONDENCE
Åsa Rejnö
asa.rejno@hv.se

RECEIVED 03 June 2026
REVISED 09 July 2026
ACCEPTED 13 July 2026
PUBLISHED 23 July 2026

CITATION
Bouwmeester Stjernetun B, Åberg C and Rejnö Å (2026) Creating spaces for norm-critical reflection: lessons from the NormDay initiative in health and healthcare education.
Front. Educ. 11:1899614.
doi: 10.3389/feduc.2026.1899614

COPYRIGHT
© 2026 Bouwmeester Stjernetun, Åberg and Rejnö. This is an open-access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License (CC BY). The use, distribution or reproduction in other forums is permitted, provided the original author(s) and the copyright owner(s) are credited and that the original publication in this journal is cited, in accordance with accepted academic practice. No use, distribution or reproduction is permitted which does not comply with these terms.

Creating spaces for norm-critical reflection: lessons from the NormDay initiative in health and healthcare education

Björn Bouwmeester Stjernetun[1], Christèl Åberg[2] and Åsa Rejnö[2,3,4]*

[1]School of Health Sciences, University of Skövde, Skövde, Sweden, [2]Department of Health Sciences, University West, Trollhättan, Sweden, [3]Skaraborg Institute of Research and Development, Skövde, Sweden, [4]Department of Medicine, Skaraborg Hospital Skövde, Skövde, Sweden

In a context where academic freedom is increasingly challenged and exclusionary norms are gaining renewed strength; there is a growing need for educational approaches that foster critical reflection and inclusive perspectives. Conferences have traditionally been viewed as sites for disseminating research, yet their potential as spaces for experiential and transformative learning remains underexplored. This perspective article presents a practice-based case analysis of *NormDay* as a student initiated educational and organisational innovation, drawing on observational material and participant survey data. Drawing on a norm-critical framework, NormDay combined keynote lectures with participatory workshops, exhibitions, and experience-based activities aimed at disrupting taken-for-granted assumptions and encouraging perspective taking. The initiative brought together researchers, educators, students, practitioners, policymakers, and civil society actors, creating a shared arena for dialogue across sectors. Participant evaluations indicated high levels of engagement and perceived relevance, as well as a self-reported increase in norm awareness. Rather than positioning NormDay as an intervention in the experimental sense, the article conceptualizes it as an awareness-oriented academic practice that may initiate processes of change over time. Key lessons include the importance of participatory formats, cross-sector collaboration, and the integration of embodied learning experiences. At the same time, challenges related to participant reach and the sustainability of impact are highlighted. The article contributes to ongoing discussions on academic freedom and norm-critical pedagogy by illustrating how higher education can create reflective spaces that address exclusionary norms and support more equitable health and healthcare practices.

KEYWORDS
awareness, conference, equity in health, higher education, inclusion, norm-critique, norms, reflective space

1 Introduction

The societal climate is hardening in many countries; democracies are under threat, and people who fall outside what is considered "normal" are increasingly marginalized. In addition, migration and large-scale population movements as a result of war and persecution contribute to heightened tension in many countries that receive people seeking refuge.

Academic freedom is associated with both institutional autonomy and, at the individual level, researchers' ability to express themselves and share their work. According to a recent report, academic freedom has declined in 50 countries over the past decade, including countries traditionally considered democracies (Kinzelbach et al., 2026).

Moreover, the ability to question established truths, render power structures visible, and foreground marginalized perspectives, require an academic climate in which researchers and teachers can express themselves without fear of censorship or reprisals. At a time when certain concepts and areas of research are questioned or even banned in different parts of the world, it becomes evident that academic freedom cannot be taken for granted but must be continuously defended (Dahlborg et al., 2025).

Conferences provide spaces for researchers to share ideas, socialize, and expand their professional networks (Hauss, 2021). They are distinguished from other work environments by enabling intensive interaction among actors who may meet only occasionally, shaped by the temporal and spatial constraints of the conference setting (González-Santos and Dimond, 2015).

Beyond formal presentations, conferences facilitate formal and informal knowledge exchange through diverse activities and interactions, with other researchers, which might have an impact at both individual and collective levels (Hauss, 2021). They are also arenas where ideas are negotiated, where notions of relevant or interesting research are discussed, and where future directions can be anticipated (González-Santos and Dimond, 2015). In this sense, conferences play a crucial role in sustaining academic communities, as their short-term face-to-face interactions support the maintenance and development of collaborations and partnerships (de Leon and McQuillin, 2020). Despite conferences longstanding traditions, scientific production has primarily been attributed to journal publications, and the role of conferences in shaping communities and networks has received comparatively less attention (Bigg, 2023; Bigg et al., 2023).

Against this backdrop, NormDay, an initiative hosted by University West, Sweden, should be understood. The article draws on observational material and participant survey data to examine NormDay, a one-day conference aimed at fostering self-awareness of norms and norm-critical perspectives. It originated from an idea by students in the Blended Intensive Programme "Norm-Consciousness and Health", part of the EU-funded Breaking Fences project (Courses - Breaking Fences). NormDay also functioned as an initiative highlighting academic freedom as a fundamental principle within the democratic discourse. The event was organized by the research group NormWIL, which focuses on norm-critical pedagogy, norms, and inequities in health and healthcare, operating across academic and healthcare settings to support broader societal impact.

In today's context, where threats to gender equality and human rights signal a regression rarely seen in modern times, the conference is strikingly timely. These developments emphasize the need for increased awareness of norms and their role in exclusion, as well as for collective, action-oriented initiatives. This article contributes to discussions on academic freedom and norm-critical pedagogy by presenting NormDay as an academic initiative and analysing it as a norm-critical practice, offering insights into how higher education can create reflective spaces to address exclusionary norms in health and healthcare education.

2 Conceptual and theoretical background

Norms are shared expectations or informal rules that guide and constrain behavior within social groups, shaping what individuals perceive as appropriate or acceptable actions (Bicchieri, 2006). By defining which behaviors, values, and identities are considered legitimate, norms delineate boundaries between "we" and "them." Individuals who conform to dominant norms are typically recognized as insiders, while those who do not - or cannot - meet these expectations risk being positioned as outsiders. Although such processes can foster internal cohesion, they may also contribute to exclusion, stigmatization, or marginalization. Norms also coordinate expectations and behavior, while shaping group identities, sometimes producing discriminatory outcomes.

Becoming aware of norms is a crucial first step in recognizing how norms operate, how individuals position themselves in relation to prevailing norms, and the consequences norms generate (Tengelin, 2019). Such awareness represents an initial stage in a potential process of change toward more inclusive ways of understanding and acting. A key challenge lies not only in theorizing norms, but in creating conditions that enable individuals and groups to reflect on, experience, and question norms in practice. Despite increasing attention to norms and equity in health and healthcare education, such issues are often addressed through abstract discussions or isolated training sessions, leaving limited space for collective, experiential engagement.

In response to this challenge, NormDay can be understood as an action-oriented innovation designed to foster norm awareness through participatory engagement. What distinguishes the initiatives is its broad, creative, and boundary crossing approach. It was student-initiated, not solely researcher-driven, and designed as a co-creative platform where diverse actors, including artists, civil society representatives, researchers, students, and librarians, were given a central role, thereby challenging conventional assumptions about who produces and legitimises knowledge within academic and educational contexts. Rather than targeting a specific audience, NormDay convened actors from across the health sector and wider community, creating a shared arena for diverse perspectives to meet and challenge one another.

A defining characteristic of NormDay was its participatory format. Rather than positioning participants as passive listeners, the program centered on workshops, interactive exhibitions, and activities intentionally designed to challenge taken for granted norms. Drawing on experiential learning principles (Kolb and Kolb, 2018), it aimed to disrupt unexamined assumptions, facilitate perspective shifts, and create space for embodied learning. By combining theoretical insights with experience-based elements, NormDay enabled both literal and figurative forms of perspective-taking. In this way, it extended beyond traditional conference formats, functioning not merely as a site of knowledge dissemination (González-Santos and Dimond, 2015) but as a reflective and transformative space for engaging with and understanding norms in new ways.

3 From idea to implementation: process and participants

Planning for NormDay originated from the students' idea of dedicating a full day to norm awareness. From the outset, the event aimed to differ from conventional conferences by adopting a more interactive and participatory format aimed at challenging norms. The planning process focused on formats that could support interaction, participation, and critical engagement beyond conventional structures.

NormWILs longstanding focus on norms, norm critical perspectives, and equity was a significant asset in both planning and implementation. Without this foundation, assembling an initiative of this scope and character would have been considerably more challenging. The group's extended networks also facilitated the identification and engagement of lecturers and stakeholders able and willing to contribute to the program.

NormDay attracted a diverse group of participants across sectors and roles. Participants were predominantly women ($n = 85$, 83%). Nearly half of the participants ($n = 49$, 48%) were working within academia, 22% ($n = 23$) held roles in leadership, strategy, or administration. Students constituted 17% of participants, while professionals within healthcare represented 7% ($n = 7$). Smaller groups were engaged in cultural and artistic fields ($n = 3$, 2.5%), reflecting the cross-sectoral and interdisciplinary ambition of NormDay.

4 NormDay as an initiative: pedagogical design and practice

NormDay can be understood as an academic initiative characterised by a pedagogical design aimed at challenging and inspiring new perspectives on societal norms. Drawing on norm-critical and norm-creative approaches, the program combined keynote lectures, workshops, exhibitions, and poster presentations to emphasize active, participatory, and experience-based engagement rather than passive knowledge dissemination. Participants were invited to engage with norms through embodied, dialogical, and reflective activities, fostering critical reflection on their role in health and healthcare.

While NormDay incorporated elements associated with academic conferences, such as research-based keynote lectures (for example, a lecture on norm-critical design), these were integrated with interactive and practice-oriented formats. Together, they provided a shared scholarly frame of reference for the day's participatory and experience-based activities.

All components of NormDay were selected to ensure breadth and the inclusion of multiple perspectives. Representatives from civil society organizations working on norms, inclusion, and equity were invited to contribute. Experience-based and participatory activities were prioritized over traditional presentation formats to challenge assumptions and enable participants to engage with and sense how norms operate at individual level, but also within and between groups.

Civil society stakeholders were invited to contribute to NormDay with a high degree of autonomy in shaping their own participation. For example, a migrant led organization, and a culture centre with a collective of artists, designers, and craftspeople, contributed with a workshop and an exhibition respectively, featuring norm challenging practices and art.

One example of a research-connected, experience-based activity was a workshop in which participants engaged with ageing using an age simulation suit. The design of this activity was grounded in an approach that links experiencing, reflecting, thinking and acting, aiming to make taken for granted assumptions about ageing and bodily function available for critical examination. The suit is designed to simulate age-related health problems of old age, for example stiff joints, impaired vision, reduced grip strength, slower and unstable gait. The combination of these impairments can be used as didactic strategy to simulate the everyday struggles an older person may experience. Participants were invited to test the suit and to "walk in the shoes" of an older person. By providing a physical experience of a body that is restricted and does not respond as usual, the activity created a starting point for participants to explore how such conditions may shape everyday life. The session was facilitated by researchers with specific expertise in the area with a focus on connecting participants' embodied experiences to broader reflections on norms and age-related assumptions.

Participants wearing the suit were asked to perform common daily tasks, such as taking a short walk, buttoning a cardigan, and retrieving tablets from a medication bottle. Tasks that are typically carried out without reflection became difficult and, in some cases, frustrating. This shift from the familiar to the unfamiliar was intentionally designed to prompt reflection and discussion, and to support a movement from immediate experience toward more critical examination.

Experience based activities of this kind have been shown to counteract prejudice and unconscious discrimination (Gerhardy et al., 2022) here directed toward older adults, often referred to as ageism, by challenging what is commonly taken for granted in relation to ageing and bodily function. By disrupting the "natural attitude" through an out of the ordinary experience, such activities can ignite learning processes that question preexisting assumptions and forms of pre-understanding (Ekebergh, 2007).

Although participants only wore the suit for a limited period of time, several remarked that "it was valuable to try this". Participants generally described the loss of vision as the most challenging aspect of the experience, followed by limitations in

arm mobility, while reduced mobility in the legs was perceived as less restrictive. These observations align well with previous research (Bouwmeester Stjernetun et al., 2024). Interestingly, these reflections stood in contrast to remarks made by one of the keynote speakers from Gothenburg Independent Living (GIL), who noted that many people claim they would rather be dead than live the rest of their lives dependent on a wheelchair. The juxtaposition of these perspectives created an opportunity to move from individual experience to collective reflection, opening up critical discussion about assumptions concerning dependency, bodily function, and quality of life.

5 Evaluation approach and findings

To evaluate NormDay, a brief online survey was distributed to all participants within one week of the event. The survey consisted of three closed-ended questions, along with opportunities for respondents to provide reflections in free-text format. The purpose was to gain an initial understanding of participants' experiences and to inform reflections on the design and future development of similar initiatives. The response rate was 25%, which can be considered relatively robust for voluntary post-event evaluations (Wu et al., 2022).

Participants' responses were overall positive. NormDay received high ratings for overall organization (mean score 4.4 on a 5-point scale). Participants also rated the day as relevant and engaging (mean score 4.1 out of 5). In addition, they reported a perceived increase in their awareness and understanding of social norms and their impact on health and healthcare (mean score 3.9 out of 5) based on a single-item question assessing the extent to which NormDay contributed to such an increase (1 = Not at all, 5 = Significantly).

The free-text responses highlighted increased awareness of norms, enhanced perspective-taking, and exposure to diverse perspectives as key outcomes. Experiential activities, including workshops and artistic elements, were seen as particularly impactful in fostering reflection. The integration of norm-critical and design perspectives, along with cross-sectoral dialogue, further contributed to new insights and understandings.

A limitation of the evaluation is that it does not capture long-term effects of NormDay, such as sustained changes in participants' perspectives or actions. Future events are intended to incorporate repeated measures to explore longer-term impacts more systematically.

6 Discussion

NormDay represents a context-specific initiative situated within a particular institutional and national setting. Rather than aiming for empirical generalization, this article offers conceptual and reflective insights that may inform similar initiatives in other educational and professional contexts concerned with norms, equity, and health. The discussion focuses on key lessons learned from the implementation and evaluation of NormDay and their implications for future research and practice.

Despite careful planning and broad ambitions, participation did not reach all intended groups. Participants primarily represented managers within the healthcare sector, as well as educators, students, colleagues, and researchers from nearby universities. The organisers also sought to engage care providers, campus-based students, and members of the general public associated with the university; however, this ambition was only partially achieved.

Rather than being understood solely as a practical challenge, this pattern of participation may also reflect how norm-critical initiatives are positioned and perceived. Engagement may reflect existing professional, institutional, and epistemic orientations, with individuals already familiar with or interested in issues of norms and equity more likely to participate. Participation in voluntary initiatives may also be shaped by implicit expectations regarding relevance, legitimacy, and priority, affecting who feels addressed or motivated to attend.

The fact that participation in this inaugural event was free of charge may have lowered the threshold for late cancellations; however, it also illustrates how access alone does not ensure engagement. These observations highlight the importance of considering not only logistical factors, but also how invitations, framing, and institutional contexts shape participation and non-participation. As de Leon and McQuillin (2020) note, conferences can facilitate knowledge spillover effect, but such effects remain contingent on who is present.

Although NormDay was open to all, women were overrepresented, accounting for 83% of attendees. This likely reflects broader patterns in healthcare, and engagement with equality-related issues, where women are more strongly represented. For example, approximately 90% of registered nurses in Sweden are women. At the same time, the imbalance highlights the need to consider how participation in norm-critical initiatives may be shaped by gendered patterns of engagement and how such initiatives can be designed to reach a broader and more diverse audience.

Lower-than-expected participation among campus students warrants particular attention. Student identities in higher education are fluid and shape attitudes toward engagement and learning (Thunborg et al., 2013). Students oriented toward lifelong learning tend to show greater interest in voluntary and non-compulsory educational activities, whereas instrumental students often display a more limited engagement, viewing higher education primarily as a means to external goals such as employability or credentialing. According to Thunborg et al. (2013) such instrumental orientations have become more prominent as higher education has shifted from an elite to a mass education system. Participation in a voluntary initiative such as NormDay, may therefore be influenced not only by interest in the topic but also by how students prioritise activities beyond their core studies. The distinction between interest and participation thus becomes important: while NormDay may be perceived as relevant or valuable, this does not necessarily translate into attendance when engagement remains voluntary. These findings point to the need to

consider not only on communication strategies, but also how the format, timing, and positioning of initiatives such as NormDay align with students' conditions for participation.

NormDay should be understood as an awareness-oriented initiative designed to create spaces for reflection, perspective-taking, and critical engagement with norms. Such initiatives do not in themselves produce change, but may represent an initial step in processes that, over time, can contribute to altered practices and understanding of norm awareness in health and healthcare education.

One of the more promising outcomes of NormDay was the cross-sector networking that emerged during and after the event. From this perspective, NormDay should be understood not as an endpoint, but as part of an ongoing dialogue on health, care, and societal norms. In addition to participant evaluations, systematic feedback from keynote speakers and workshop leaders has been recognized and will be incorporated into future evaluations.

Allowing civil society stakeholders to define the content and form of their contributions was an intentional decision. From a norm-critical perspective, this approach can be understood as an effort to decentre academic authority and create space for knowledge grounded in lived experience, artistic expression, and community-based practice. In line with Fricker's (2007) concept of *epistemic injustice*, such practices challenge epistemic hierarchies in which certain voices and forms of knowledge are granted greater credibility than others. This pluralisation of knowledge helps counteract testimonial marginalization and aligns with the initiative's broader ambition to address norms and inequities in health and healthcare.

While NormDay was designed to foster inclusive and participatory engagement, it is important to recognise that such formats may not be equally accessible to all participants. Activities emphasising interaction, dialogue, and co-creation may pose barriers for individuals less comfortable with social engagement or unfamiliar contexts. Although participation was supported through structured formats and conference hosts, these measures may not accommodate all participants' needs. To increase accessibility, the morning sessions were available online; however, the afternoon programme, which included multiple parallel in-person workshops, could not be offered in the same format. This highlights how different modes of participation may enable or constrain access.

In addition, the framing of the event, including the use of the term "norm", may be interpreted in different ways and influence who feels invited or addressed. These considerations underline the need to reflect on how norm-critical initiatives can be designed to accommodate a broader range of participants and forms of engagement.

While modest in scope, the evaluation provided initial insights into participants' experiences of NormDay and offered a basis for reflecting on its design, implementation, and potential contribution to raising awareness of norms in health and healthcare education. Together, these reflections point to the value of participatory, action-oriented academic initiatives, while underscoring the need for ongoing critical evaluation and contextual sensitivity.

7 Concluding reflections and future directions

The findings of this study highlight several important considerations for future development of initiatives such as NormDay. While the event was associated with positive immediate experiences, questions remain regarding its longer-term impact on participants' perspectives and professional practices, indicating a need for more sustained and systematic forms of evaluation.

There is also potential to strengthen the academic dimension of such initiatives by creating additional opportunities for scholarly engagement, for example through abstract submission, poster and oral presentations, and facilitated panel discussions. However, this points to a potential tension between strengthening academic forms of knowledge and the ambition to decentre academic authority, highlighting the need to balance scholarly engagement with diverse forms of knowledge and participation. This tension underscores the importance of preserving the participatory and experience-based character of such initiatives, which appears central to fostering meaningful engagement and critical reflection.

NormDay also illustrates the potential of initiatives that bring together perspectives from research, education, practice, and civil society. By supporting dialogue across these domains, such formats may contribute to a more integrated understanding of norm-critical perspectives in health and healthcare.

Although threats to human rights and democratic values may appear distant in many countries, recent international developments illustrate how rapidly circumstances can change, often leaving societies unprepared. Measures affecting research agendas, language use, and academic freedom serve as reminders that such values cannot be taken for granted. In this light, initiatives such as NormDay may play an important role in creating spaces for critical reflection and dialogue. By highlighting how norms shape health, healthcare, and lived experiences, and by fostering embodied and participatory engagement, such initiatives can help address areas where silence or unexamined assumptions have previously prevailed.

Data availability statement

The original contributions presented in the study are included in the article/Supplementary Material, further inquiries can be directed to the corresponding author.

Author contributions

BB: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Conceptualization. CÅ: Conceptualization, Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft. ÅR: Writing – original draft, Supervision, Conceptualization, Writing – review & editing.

Funding

The author(s) declared that financial support was not received for this work and/or its publication.

Acknowledgments

We thank our colleagues in the NormAIL research group for their insightful and valuable comments on the manuscript.

Conflict of interest

The author(s) declared that this work was conducted in the absence of any commercial or financial relationships that could be construed as a potential conflict of interest.

Generative AI statement

The author(s) declared that generative AI was not used in the creation of this manuscript.

Any alternative text (alt text) provided alongside figures in this article has been generated by Frontiers with the support of artificial intelligence and reasonable efforts have been made to ensure accuracy, including review by the authors wherever possible. If you identify any issues, please contact us.

Publisher's note

All claims expressed in this article are solely those of the authors and do not necessarily represent those of their affiliated organizations, or those of the publisher, the editors and the reviewers. Any product that may be evaluated in this article, or claim that may be made by its manufacturer, is not guaranteed or endorsed by the publisher.

References

Bicchieri, C. (2006). *The Grammar of Society: The Nature and Dynamics of Social Norms*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Bigg, C. (2023). Communicating science, mediating presence: reflections on the present, past and future of conferencing. *Br. J. Hist. Sci.* 56, 567–577. doi: 10.1017/S0007087423000365

Bigg, C., Reinisch, J., Somsen, G., and Widmalm, S. (2023). The art of gathering: histories of international scientific conferences. *Br. J. Hist. Sci.* 56, 423–433. doi: 10.1017/S0007087423000638

Bouwmeester Stjernetun, B., Gillsjö, C., Odzakovic, E., and Hallgren, J. (2024). It´s like walking in a bubble", nursing students perspectives on age suit simulation in a home environment - group interviews from reflection seminars. *BMC. Nurs.* 23, 124. doi: 10.1186/s12912-024-01792-5

Dahlborg, E., Castillo, I. A., and Tengelin, E. (2025). When academic freedom becomes dangerous: nursing in an age of censorship. *Nurs. Inq.* 32, e70044. doi: 10.1111/nin.70044

De Leon, F. L. L., and Mcquillin, B. (2020). The role of conferences on the pathway to academic impact. *J. Hum. Resour.* 55, 164. doi: 10.3368/jhr.55.1.1116-8387R

Ekebergh, M. (2007). Lifeworld-based reflection and learning: a contribution to the reflective practice in nursing and nursing education. *Reflect. Pract.* 8, 331–343. doi: 10.1080/14623940701424835

Fricker, M. (2007). *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Gerhardy, T. H., Schlomann, A., Wahl, H. W., and Schmidt, L. I. (2022). Effects of age simulation suits on psychological and physical outcomes: a systematic review. *Eur. J. Ageing.* 19, 953–976. doi: 10.1007/s10433-022-00722-1

González-Santos, S., and Dimond, R. (2015). Medical and scientific conferences as sites of sociological interest: a review of the field. *Sociol. Compass.* 9, 235–245. doi: 10.1111/soc4.12250

Hauss, K. (2021). What are the social and scientific benefits of participating at academic conferences? Insights from a survey among doctoral students and postdocs in Germany. *Res. Eval.* 30, 1–12. doi: 10.1093/reseval/rvaa018

Kinzelbach, K., Lindberg, S. I., Lott, L., and Panaro, A. V. (2026). Academic Freedom Index Update 2026.

Kolb, A., and Kolb, D. (2018). Eight important things to know about the experiential learning cycle. *Australian Educ. Lead.* 40, 8–14.

Tengelin, E. (2019) *Becoming aware of blind spots — norm-critical perspectives on healthcare education*. Jönköping: Jönköping University, School of Health and Welfare.

Thunborg, C., Bron, A., and Edström, E. (2013). Motives, commitment and student identity in higher education—experiences of non-traditional students in Sweden. *Stud. Educ. Adults* 45, 177–193. doi: 10.1080/02660830.2013.11661650

Wu, M.-J., Zhao, K., and Fils-Aime, F. (2022). Response rates of online surveys in published research: a meta-analysis. *Comput. Hum. Behav. Rep.* 7, 100206. doi: 10.1016/j.chbr.2022.100206